Page skeleton

1

When to use it: Use before you add any content to a new page.

Checklist

- [ ] Starts with <!doctype html>
- [ ] <html> has lang="en-AU"
- [ ] Character set is UTF-8
- [ ] The page has a descriptive title
- [ ] One <h1> and the paragraph are in the body
- [ ] Check that the page passes the validator with no errors
- [ ] Read the title aloud: would it make sense in a list of browser tabs?

Worked example

```
<!doctype html>
<html lang="en-AU">
  <head>
    <meta charset="utf-8">
    <title>Leave policy update — Staff
portal</title>
  </head>
  <body>
    <h1>Leave policy update</h1>
    <p>From 1 July, you can request leave
through the staff portal.</p>
  </body>
</html>
```

Semantic structure

2

When to use it: Use when you build or review a page layout.

Checklist

- [ ] A <header> holds the one <h1>
- [ ] The stories are inside <main>
- [ ] Each story has an <h2>
- [ ] No skipped heading levels
- [ ] The copyright line is in a <footer>
- [ ] “Entries close Friday” uses
- [ ] Use a browser outline tool or a screen reader’s heading list to check the order
- [ ] Use CSS, not headings, to change text size

Worked example

```
<!doctype html>
<html lang="en-AU">
  <head>
    <meta charset="utf-8">
    <title>Team news</title>
  </head>
  <body>
    <header>
      <h1>Team news</h1>
    </header>
    <main>
      <h2>New starter: Priya</h2>
      <p>Priya joins the web team on Monday.
</p>
      <h2>Photo competition</h2>
      <p>Send us your best workplace photo.
<strong>Entries close Friday.</strong></p>
    </main>
    <footer>© 2026 Shammim</footer>
  </body>
</html>
```

Links and images

3

When to use it: Use whenever you add a link or an image.

Checklist

- [ ] The link goes to https://example.com/careers
- [ ] The link text describes where it goes
- [ ] The team photo has meaningful alt text
- [ ] The decorative divider has alt=""
- [ ] The photo has width and height
- [ ] Read the link text on its own: does it say where it goes?
- [ ] Ask: if the image didn't load, what would someone need to know?

Worked example

```
<!doctype html>
<html lang="en-AU">
  <head>
    <meta charset="utf-8">
    <title>Careers — Shammim</title>
  </head>
  <body>
    <h1>Work with us</h1>
    <img src="images/team-photo.jpg"
alt="Five members of the web team standing
together" width="800" height="533">
    <img src="images/divider.svg" alt="">
    <p>We're hiring a content designer. <a
href="https://example.com/careers">See
current jobs at Shammim</a>.</p>
  </body>
</html>
```

© 2026 Shammim. All rights reserved.

Tables

4

When to use it: Use for data in rows and columns, never for page layout.

Checklist

- [ ] The table has a caption
- [ ] Header row is in <thead> with <th scope="col">
- [ ] Data rows are in <tbody>
- [ ] Each day is a row header (<th scope="row">)
- [ ] Names are still data cells (<td>)
- [ ] Keep tables simple: split very complex tables into smaller ones
- [ ] Check the table on a phone screen

Worked example

```
<!doctype html>
<html lang="en-AU">
  <head>
    <meta charset="utf-8">
    <title>Help desk roster</title>
    <style>table{border-
collapse:collapse}th,td{border:1px solid
#6F8C87;padding:6px 10px;text-
align:left}caption{font-weight:bold;text-
align:left;padding-bottom:6px}</style>
  </head>
  <body>
    <h1>Help desk roster</h1>
    <table>
      <caption>Help desk roster, this
week</caption>
      <thead>
        <tr><th scope="col">Day</th><th
scope="col">Morning</th><th
scope="col">Afternoon</th></tr>
      </thead>
      <tbody>
        <tr><th scope="row">Monday</th>
<td>Sam</td><td>Priya</td></tr>
        <tr><th scope="row">Tuesday</th>
<td>Alex</td><td>Mei</td></tr>
        <tr><th scope="row">Wednesday</th>
<td>Priya</td><td>Sam</td></tr>
      </tbody>
    </table>
  </body>
</html>
```

Accessible forms

5

When to use it: Use for every form, however short.

Checklist

- [ ] The name field has a visible label
- [ ] The email field has a visible label
- [ ] Email is type="email" and required
- [ ] The radio buttons are in a fieldset with a legend
- [ ] The form is sent with a real button
- [ ] Every field has an accessible name
- [ ] Complete the form with the keyboard only
- [ ] Check that error messages say how to fix the problem

Worked example

```
<!doctype html>
<html lang="en-AU">
  <head>
    <meta charset="utf-8">
    <title>Event feedback</title>
  </head>
  <body>
    <h1>Event feedback</h1>
    <form>
      <p>
        <label for="name">Name</label>
        <input type="text" id="name"
autocomplete="name">
      </p>
      <p>
        <label for="email">Email (required)
</label>
        <input type="email" id="email"
autocomplete="email" required>
      </p>
      <fieldset>
        <legend>How useful was the event?
</legend>
        <input type="radio" id="r1"
name="rating" value="1"><label for="r1">Not
useful</label>
        <input type="radio" id="r2"
name="rating" value="2"><label
for="r2">Useful</label>
        <input type="radio" id="r3"
name="rating" value="3"><label for="r3">Very
useful</label>
…
```